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The summer transfer window saw its first major move when India international Anwar Ali terminated his loan deal with Mohun Bagan Super Giant and transferred to archrival East Bengal for Rs. 2.5 crore. The dust is yet to settle on the transfer as Anwar has been banned until the end of the year by the AIFF Players' Status Committee after Mohun Bagan disputed that the player terminated his contract "without a just cause". The player, however, can appeal the verdict.

Only Mohun Bagan, Kerala Blasters, and Punjab FC have made changes to their coaching personnel in the off-season. Jose Molina, who was the sporting director at the Royal Spanish Football Federation, will return to the coaching dugout with Mohun Bagan.

Who are the contenders?

On the field, it's hard to look past Mohun Bagan Super Giant and Mumbai City FC, as the two have shared the League Shield and the Cup between them over the last two seasons. Bagan splashed the cash to lure Lalengmawia Ralte from Mumbai City FC, adding to its already strong Indian midfield core, while Mumbai City has roped in Brandon Fernandes from FC Goa on a free transfer.

Mumbai City has refreshed its overseas roster with relatively younger players. Spaniard and La Masia graduate Jon Toral, who has had top-flight experience in Spain, Scotland, and Greece, is a significant signing for the Islanders. Meanwhile, Mohun Bagan has bolstered its attack with Jamie Maclaren, the A-League's all-time top scorer, who will link up with last season's best player, Dimitri Petratos.

Bagan has gone top-heavy this season with Maclaren, Petratos, Jason Cummings, and Greg Stewart, leaving no room for an overseas central midfielder. The onus will fall on the Indian midfielders to control the game from the middle of the

park, a role Joni Kauko played in previous seasons.

FC Goa could have faced a major setback if the AIFF had bought out Manolo Marquez's contract last month. Instead, Marquez will divide his time between his club and the national team this season, before taking on a full-time national role in 2025-26. Ahead of the season opener, Marquez was busy with the Intercontinental Cup in Hyderabad while his club side won the competitive Bandodkar Trophy, which featured strong teams like Brisbane Roar (A-League) and Defensa y Justicia (Argentina's Primera Division). Goa's title chances will hinge on how Marquez handles his dual role.

Odisha FC, runner-up to Goa in the final, has retained most of its foreign core while adding ISL's prolific attacking midfielder Hugo Boumous. Odisha challenged for the top spot for most of last season before fading away, but Sergio Lobera will be optimistic about adding to his team's solitary Super Cup title.

Challengers for the playoffs

The loss of Anwar for more than

half a season will no doubt hurt Carles Cuadrat's East Bengal. The club was also handed a two window transfer ban and a hefty fine to pay to Mohun Bagan. Besides spending a mammoth Rs. 3.3 crore in transfer fees to secure defensive midfielder Jeakson Singh from the Blasters, the club also signed Dimitrios Diamantakos and Madhi Talal, the best players from Blasters and Punjab FC, respectively, last season. David Lalhlansanga, I-League's top Indian scorer last season, has also made the step up to the Red and Golds.

NorthEast United FC finally shed its perennial underachiever tag last month by winning its first-ever trophy, defeating a full-strength Mohun Bagan in the Durand Cup final. Juan Pedro Benali brought the Highlanders within a point of a playoff spot last season, and the club

Drama continues: The dust is yet to settle on Anwar Ali's transfer as he has been banned until the end of the year by the AIFF Players' Status Committee after Mohun Bagan disputed that the player terminated his contract "without a just cause". SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

